

Linguistics and semiotics

Several subjects previously thought of as branches of philosophy emerged as scientific disciplines in the 19th century. As well as psychology, economics and sociology, thinkers began to apply scientific methods to the study of language. One of the pioneers in this field of 'linguistics' was Ferdinand de Saussure, who examined the structure of language and developed a theory that it is made up of 'linguistic signs' signifying concepts. This idea became the basis of semiotics, the study of signs and the relationships between the signifier – the sign itself – and the signified – the concept. Analysis of the use of language and signs was given a political dimension by Roland Barthes, who applied semiotic theories to literary criticism and culture in general. As a Marxist, he explained how signs could be used to impose bourgeois cultural values. His scientific approach to the analysis of literature and language, especially with its left-wing tendency, was highly influential on the generation of French philosophers that followed Sartre and Camus, the structuralists.

Signified (concept)



Signifier ('sound image')